



Dead End DRIIFT

The death of Prabhakaran leaves a question mark on the Rajiv Gandhi assassination probe

By Sandeep Unnithan

Every day over 40 CBI officials file into the office of the Multi-Disciplinary Monitoring Agency (MDMA) at Jam Nagar House, a cluster of hutments in the heart of Lutyens' Delhi, set beside offices of the Directorate of Adult Education and the Directorate of Food and Public Distribution. Their onerous task? To explore the larger conspiracy behind the assassination of Rajiv Gandhi. It has been over 18 years since a LTTE suicide bomber blew herself up, killing the former prime minister. The prime accused have been sentenced to death and are awaiting the President's decision on their mercy petitions. Yet the investigations have been hanging fire for over a decade, turning it into one of the world's longest probes into a political murder. Today, the MDMA, set up under the CBI in 1998, with a branch in Chennai, is

nowhere close to finding the truth behind Rajiv's assassination. The recent deaths of two of the three prime conspirators behind the killing of Rajiv—LTTE chief V. Prabhakaran and head of its intelligence wing Pottu Amman—have put a question mark on the existence of the agency. (The CBI says it is yet to get death certificates of the two prime accused from the Sri Lankan Government so that they can shut the case). Even the Supreme Court has recently asked if investigations into the Rajiv assassination were still on when the key planners were dead. "The MDMA is a defunct organisation and is being kept alive only because of 10 Janpath," admits a CBI official.

Officially, the agency's tenure is due to expire on May 31. But a week before this deadline, its office hardly reflects any sign of a shutdown. The MDMA in Delhi continues to function under Joint

Director N.R. Vasan, two DIGs and two SPS who report to the CBI director.

Yet, the show must go on. At least eight investigating officials attached to the agency have since been reassigned to cases like probing the Delhi Development Authority land grabbing scam. One MDMA official, who retired three years ago, has been re-employed by the government because of his alleged proximity to a political party. The agency is often treated as a dumping ground for CBI officials. The Chennai branch has been headless ever since the SP, who was in charge, was transferred to the Anti-Corruption Bureau, over a year ago. Today, it functions with an inspector and three staffers.

"As per the court order, the proceedings of the designated court under the TADA Act, Chennai, are to be held in-camera keeping in view the sensitive nature of the case. Moreover, the infor-

